

Heidegger on Being and the World

Wednesdays at 1pm in 1008 B, Cathedral of Learning

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The course website, with a week-by-week schedule and all the readings, is available at:

<https://spaceofreasons.netlify.app/courses/heidegger-2026/>

Or by drilling down under the “Courses” tab from my Pitt website:

<https://sites.pitt.edu/~rbrandom/>

Week 7: October 7, 2026

Falling [Verfallen]: Gerede, Neugier, Zweideutigkeit

Plan:

- Recap: Befindlichkeit, Verstehen, and Rede. Verstehen and Rede distinguished by:
 - Modal articulation: **axiological proprieties** and **attitude-dependent deontic statuses**.
 - Content-form: Verstehen as this-such, Rede as propositional: das Worüber and das Geredetes.

Das Worüber is what one makes oneself responsible *to* in judging.
Das Geredetes is what one makes oneself responsible *for* in judging.
Within Rede, Aussage has both kinds of content, Gerede has only das Geredetes.
- Relations of mutual presupposition between Gerede and Aussage, within Rede:
 - i) Rede cannot consist entirely of Gerede, without Aussage.
 - ii) Rede cannot consist entirely of Aussage, without Gerede.

Both of these are *semantic* dependences that involve *pragmatic* dependences.
Point of comparison for (ii): Gerede : Aussage :: analytic : synthetic.
- **Falling = Gerede, Neugier, Zweideutigkeit.** Falling is an essentially *discursive* phenomenon.
- **Conformist Gravity Principle:** Genuine commitment is hard, and Dasein is lazy. (?)
Status and rationale for a version of this as a basic ontological phenomenon.
- **Chiaroscuro Principle:** No light without shade, no revealing without concealing.
 - erschließen (to disclose/open up) and verschließen (to close off/lock up), ontologically.
 - Entdecken and Verdecken, ontically.

Status and rationale for this as a basic ontological phenomenon.

* I am inclined to believe, though there is almost no basis for it in the text, that the ur-phenomenon of telling [Rede] is telling whether behavior does or does not accord with the common norms—in effect, telling right from wrong. Such telling would indeed be the originary articulation of significance and would, at the same time, be fundamental to the possibility of correctness (e.g., of assertions). [Haugeland, “Dasein’s Disclosedness” (1989) pp. 34-35.]

* BB: I think this is wrong.

"So you are saying that human agreement decides what is true and what is false?"—It is what human beings say that is true and false; and they agree in the language they use. That is not agreement in opinions but in form of life. [Wittgenstein, *Philosophical Investigations* §241]

If language is to be a means of communication there must be agreement not only in definitions but also (queer as this may sound) in judgments. This seems to abolish logic, but does not do so. [Wittgenstein, *PI* §242]

The "Lockean Proviso":

There is one unerring mark by which a man may know whether he plays the lover of truth for truth's sake; viz. The not entertaining any proposition with greater assurance than the proofs it is built upon will warrant. Whoever goes beyond this measure of assent, it is plain receives not the truth in the love of it; loves not truth for truth's sake, but for some other bye end. [John Locke, *An Essay Concerning Human Understanding* (1689), Book IV, Chapter XIX, § 1]

A wise man, therefore, proportions his belief to the evidence.

[David Hume, *An Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding* (Section X)]

Idle talk, curiosity and ambiguity characterize the way in which, in an everyday manner, Dasein is its 'there'—the disclosedness of Being-in-the-world. As definite existential characteristics, these are not present-at-hand in Dasein, but help to make up its Being. In these, and in the way they are interconnected in their Being, there is revealed a basic kind of Being which belongs to everydayness; we call this the "**falling**" [**Verfallen**] of Dasein. [§38 219]

On Neugier:

Dasein is always ambiguously 'there'—that is to say, in that public disclosedness of Being-with-one-another where the loudest idle talk and **the most ingenious curiosity** [Neugier] **keep 'things moving', where, in an everyday manner, everything (and at bottom nothing) is happening.** This ambiguity is always tossing to curiosity that which it seeks; and it gives idle talk the semblance of having everything decided in it. [§37 217]

On Zweideutigkeit:

When, in our everyday Being-with-one-another, we encounter the sort of thing which is accessible to everyone, and about which anyone can say anything, **it soon becomes impossible to decide what is disclosed in a genuine understanding, and what is not.** This ambiguity [Zweideutigkeit] extends not only to the world, but just as much to Being-with-one-another as such, and even to Dasein's Being towards itself. [§37 216]

"Falleness" into the 'world' means an absorption in Being-with-one-another, in so far as the latter is guided by idle talk, curiosity, and ambiguity. Through the Interpretation of falling, what we have called the "inauthenticity" of Dasein may now be defined more precisely.

[§38 220]

...it has **fallen into the world**. [§38 220]

We would also misunderstand the ontologico-existential structure of falling if we were to ascribe to it the sense of a bad and deplorable ontical property of which, perhaps, more advanced stages of human culture might be able to rid themselves. [§38 220]

Idle talk discloses to Dasein a Being towards its world, towards Others, and towards itself—a Being **in which these are understood, but in a mode of groundless floating**.

Curiosity discloses everything and anything, yet in such a way that Being-in is everywhere and nowhere.

Ambiguity hides nothing from Dasein's understanding, but only in order that Being-in-the-world should be suppressed in this uprooted "everywhere and nowhere." [§38 221]

Yet combination (*Verbindung*) does not lie in the objects, and cannot be borrowed from them through perception... on the contrary, it is an action of the understanding... **[All] combination—whether we are conscious of it or not, whether it be a combination of the manifold of intuition or of several concepts... is an act of the understanding...**

For where the understanding has not previously combined anything, neither can it dissolve (auflösen) anything, for only through it as having been combined by the understanding can anything be given to the representational power as resolved (*zerlegt*).

[(Kant, CPR, B130, § 15 ("On the Possibility of a Combination in General"))]

The One remains, the many change and pass;
Heaven's light forever shines, Earth's shadows fly;

Life, like a dome of many-coloured glass,

Stains the white radiance of Eternity,

Until Death tramples it to fragments.—Die,

If thou wouldst be with that which thou dost seek!

[Percy Bysshe Shelley, *Adonais* (1821), Stanza 52]

Idle talk and ambiguity, having seen everything, having understood everything, develop the supposition that Dasein's disclosedness, which is so available and so prevalent, can guarantee to Dasein that all the possibilities of its Being will be secure, genuine, and full. Through the self-certainty and decidedness of the "they", it gets spread abroad increasingly that there is no need of authentic understanding or the state-of-mind that goes with it. **The supposition of the "they" that one is leading and sustaining a full and genuine 'life', brings Dasein a tranquillity [Beruhigung], for which everything is 'in the best of order' and all doors are open. Falling**

Being-in-the-world, which tempts itself, is at the same time tranquillizing [beruhigend].
[§38 222]

The leading question of this chapter has been about the Being of the "there". Our theme has been the ontological Constitution of the disclosedness which essentially belongs to Dasein. The Being of that disclosedness is constituted by states-of-mind, understanding, and discourse. Its everyday kind of Being is characterized by idle talk, curiosity, and ambiguity. These show us **the movement of falling, with temptation, tranquillizing, alienation, and entanglement as its essential characteristics**. But with this analysis, the whole existential constitution of Dasein has been laid bare in its principal features, and we have obtained the phenomenal ground for a 'comprehensive' Interpretation of Dasein's Being as care. [§38 224]

The **alienation** [Entfremdung] of falling—at once **tempting** and **tranquillizing**—leads by its own movement, to Dasein's getting **entangled** [verfängt] in itself. The phenomena we have pointed out—temptation, tranquillizing, alienation and self-entangling (entanglement)—characterize the specific kind of Being which belongs to falling. **This 'movement' of Dasein in its own Being, we call its "downward plunge" [Absturz]. Dasein plunges out of itself into itself, into the groundlessness and nullity of inauthentic everydayness. But this plunge remains hidden from Dasein by 'the way things have been publicly interpreted',** so much so, indeed, that it gets interpreted as a way of 'ascending' and 'living concretely'. This downward plunge into and within the groundlessness of the inauthentic Being of the "they", has a kind of motion which constantly tears the understanding away from the projecting of authentic possibilities, and into the tranquillized supposition that it possesses everything, or that everything is within its reach. Since the understanding is thus constantly torn away from authenticity and into the "they" (though always with a sham of authenticity), the movement of falling is characterized by turbulence [Wirbel]. [§38 223]